

Instructor: Date:

Learner: Regional Branch:

Program: Center:

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Let's Start!

Writing Spot: An Inuit Legend



Learning Outcome

Describe detailed facts about events or actions in work and social contexts, in written or spoken situations.

Ask your partner:

- Why do you think people keep legends alive?
- How important do you think myths and legends are to a society?

Can Do Statements

- I can write a short narrative.
- I can write about myths and legends in different cultures.
- I can write about past situations that did not happen.





Let's Explore!

The Inuit from Northern Canada have their own myths and legends to explain the world around them.



Instructions: Read the text aloud.

A long time ago, there was a young stranger. He came into the family igloo. Around his neck was a leather strip with two large canine teeth hanging from it. "Anyone who braves this weather is considered a friend and is provided with caribou stew and a place to lay their head. I wish I had more to give you but we are a simple people", the father said. The stranger was also given a slice of bread by one of the daughters. If only the family had known what darkness would befall their wintry home.

In the morning, the young man was gone. All that remained were animal tracks outside. The father exclaimed, "Were we deceived? Was he really an animal who took the shape of a man? I wish I was less trusting." To his horror, as time passed he realized that his daughter, Sedna, was pregnant. "If only I hadn't been so welcoming to the visitor," he mumbled to his wife. The father and daughter got into their canoe. He paddled to a small island and left her there. Later that summer, the father returned to the island to collect her.

As they were coming back, a storm threatened to capsize the overloaded canoe. The father decided that if he wanted to survive the storm, he would have to throw his daughter overboard. Sedna was a strong swimmer. She caught hold of the boat and tried to climb back in. Her father took out his knife and cut off her fingers. These fingers became seals in the sea. When she reached in again, he cut off her hands. These became walruses. When she made one last daring attempt to get into the boat her father sliced through her forearms. These were transformed into whales.

Sedna sank down, down, down into the sea. Her father cried out, "If only I had been a stronger man I would have kept you close."

Sedna was transformed as she sank into the sea, becoming half-woman and half-fish. Sometimes, if you look carefully after a storm, you can see her swimming alongside the sea animals she controls.



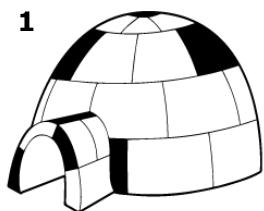
Let's Practice!

A fundamental tenet* of Inuit mythology is the belief in other worlds beneath the sea, inside the Earth and in the sky.

*A "tenet" is a belief or idea that is very important to a group.

Instructions: Read the legend again. Look at the pictures. Write sentences about them using the Past Perfect tense. Compare your sentences with your partner's.

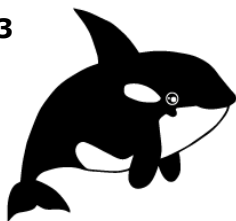
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Let's Practice!

Legends are stories about the past. Now, it's your turn to write a short narrative.

Instructions: Follow the steps to write a short narrative:

1. Write a short narrative on about a fictitious legend.
2. Develop the narrative by describing a series of events over a period of time.
3. Include characters, setting, and time in history.
4. What happened first? Second? Include a plot.
5. What do the characters learn at the end of the legend? For example: Does the legend explain the origins of certain animals (seals, walruses), land formations like mountains or why people behave a certain way?
6. Use linking words to connect ideas.
7. Describe people and places using a wide range of vocabulary.





Extension Activity

Time to learn more about Inuit culture.

Instructions: Complete the following steps. Fill in the Self-Assessment.

- Go online or to your local library and research other Inuit legends.
- Choose one legend that you are interested in. Does the legend talk about caribou, seals or whales?
- Write half a page of notes on what the legend is about. Who are the characters? What happens?
- Now write a paragraph in your own words based on the legend.
- Read your paragraph to a partner.

Self-Assessment

Yes No

I research Inuit legends.

☐ ☐

I write notes on the legend and then use those notes to write a paragraph.

☐ ☐

I read the paragraph about a legend to a partner.

☐ ☐


Target Words

- igloo** (noun): a house made of blocks of snow or ice in the form of a dome
e.g. A long time ago, a young stranger came into a family igloo.
- canine** (adjective): relating to dogs
e.g. Around his neck was a leather strip with two large canine teeth.
- caribou** (noun): a large type of deer that lives in northern parts of the world
e.g. Anyone who braves this weather is considered a friend and is provided with caribou stew.
- tracks** (noun): a mark left on the ground by a moving animal
e.g. All that remained were animal tracks outside.
- to paddle** (verb): to move a boat forward in the water with a stick with a flat end
e.g. He paddled the canoe to a small island and left her there.
- pregnant** (adjective): having a baby
e.g. To his horror, as time passed he realized that his daughter, Sedna, was pregnant.
- seal** (noun): a large animal with flippers that lives on the sea or on the coast
e.g. These fingers became seals in the sea.
- walrus** (noun): a large animal that lives on land and in the sea in northern regions and that has flippers and long tusks
e.g. Her hands became walruses.
- forearm** (noun): the part of the arm between the elbow and the wrist
e.g. When she made one last daring attempt to get into the boat her father sliced through her forearms.
- whale** (noun): an very large mammal which lives in the ocean
e.g. They turned into whales.





Learning Points

Writing in the Unreal Past

When you want to write about a hypothetical situation in the past, you use the Past Perfect tense. You can also use the word **wish** to talk about things that didn't happen, but you wanted to happen.

For example:

If only she hadn't lied to him. (= She lied and now he doesn't trust her.)

What if we had got lost in the woods?

(We didn't, but have an idea of how badly it could have turned out!)

When we use the verb **to wish** it can also followed by the Past Perfect tense. This shows that we want our present situation to be different.

I wish I had finished my degree at university. (= but I didn't finish it)

Examples:

- *I wish I had more to give you but we are simple people.*
- *I wish I was less trusting.*
- *I wish I was a more forgiving person.*
- *If only the family had known what darkness would befall their wintry home.*
- *If only I hadn't been so welcoming to the visitor.*
- *If only I had been a stronger man I would have kept you close.*





Learning Points

The Narrative

A **narrative** is a story.

It uses a sequence of events to tell the story.

The story is told by a narrator in either the 1st person (about their experience), or the 3rd person (about someone else's experience).

A narrative paints a picture of the events through the use of character, setting and plot. These are enhanced by the use of descriptive words and phrases (adjectives and adverbs).

Folktales and fairytales are classic narratives.

Parts of a Narrative	explanation
Character	person or thing with human characteristics in a story
Setting	where the story happens
Plot	the storyline featuring a beginning, middle and end

